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Financial IQ for Main Street

Wine Country Intelligence

Central Coast Wine Country Report

Santa Barbara and San Luis Obispo Counties

Q3 2026 Edition | 442 Wineries Evaluated

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A Letter from Scott

I have spent a good portion of 2026 visiting tasting rooms, cellars and offices across Santa Barbara and San Luis Obispo counties. I have sat down with nearly 100 winemakers, owners, investors and people who work around this industry, and I'm now fortunate to count several of those wineries as clients.

Everyone I talk to wants to grow. Not everyone wants to grow the same way. One winery's license will not let it pour by the glass, so it lives on bottles and club. Another does most of its business by the glass. Another opens on weekends to pour and talk, and $750,000 a year is exactly the business its owner wants. These are different businesses with different strategies, and the help on offer, from vendors and sometimes from the organizations that serve the region, too often arrives as one approach for all of them.

That matters more now, because the market is changing under every one of them. Grapes fetch less a ton, growers statewide are pulling vines, and more visitors seem to ask an AI assistant where to taste before they ask anyone else. I do not think that pressure lands evenly. Over the next year this report will look at which business models hold up and which feel the squeeze, starting with the direct-to-visitor side we measure today and widening to wholesale, which we have barely touched.

What follows is what we measured this quarter.

Scott Hess

Who AI Puts on the Shortlist

45 of 442 wineries account for 47.5% of every time a winery is named by AI

This month AI assistants gave us 2,644 answers on where to taste in each county, and named a winery 23,432 times. The 45 wineries named most often, the top tenth of the 442 we measure, account for 47.5% of those namings; the ten named most often account for 17.4%. 54 of the 442 were never named in an answer to their own county's questions.

And travelers are asking: MMGY Travel Intelligence's summer 2026 survey of 4,371 U.S. adults found that 52% of active leisure travelers have used AI to help plan a trip, up 10 points in a year.

> **Our read:** the shortlist is increasingly written by AI, and a small group of wineries is on it most of the time.

> Wine Country Intelligence clients may appear in these rankings. Clients get no preferential treatment. Every winery is measured the same way, and each one rises or falls on the work it does and on how the AI assistants read what is published about each winery, which changes from month to month as AI assistants mature.

The ten wineries named most often, both counties together:

#	Winery	Times named	County
1	Sunstone Winery	593	Santa Barbara
2	Eberle Winery	527	San Luis Obispo
3	Tablas Creek Vineyard	484	San Luis Obispo
4	DAOU Vineyards	444	San Luis Obispo
5	Roblar Winery	388	Santa Barbara
6	JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery	380	San Luis Obispo
7	Gainey Vineyard	340	Santa Barbara
8	Fess Parker Winery	330	Santa Barbara
9	Melville Winery	300	Santa Barbara
10	Halter Ranch Vineyard	292	San Luis Obispo

Times named: answers that named the winery, out of 1,324 answers about Santa Barbara County and 1,320 about San Luis Obispo County; each county is counted on its own questions.

What Changed This Quarter

Since Q2 2026, 40 Central Coast wineries were named by AI less often, and 15 more often

We asked the same 24 questions as last quarter, three times each. Of the 393 wineries we measured both times (we measure 442 this quarter; the difference is wineries that joined our census since then), 40 came up less often and 15 more often. In Santa Barbara County 22 came up less often and 8 more often; in San Luis Obispo County, 18 and 7. About as many wineries were named overall; what changed is which ones.

Most of the drop came from Perplexity and Gemini, the two of the four assistants in the set we kept unchanged from Q2 2026 that search the web for every answer: the times these wineries were named went from 343 to 225, and of those 118 fewer namings, 99 were theirs. That points to a change in what those searches now find, not necessarily at the wineries. A fall here is a change in the answers, measured; it is not a finding about the winery. If your winery is among the largest declines below, ask an AI assistant where to taste in your county and see who now appears in your place.

The largest moves each way, as the number of answers that named the winery. Last quarter we asked once; this quarter we asked three times, so each winery shows the lowest and highest of its three counts:

Largest gains

Winery	County	Q2 2026	This quarter
Beckmen Vineyards	Santa Barbara	8 of 48	12 to 16 of 48
Tablas Creek Vineyard	San Luis Obispo	19 of 48	21 to 23 of 48
Calcareous Vineyard	San Luis Obispo	3 of 48	5 to 7 of 48
Claiborne & Churchill Winery	San Luis Obispo	10 of 48	11 to 14 of 48
Coquelicot Organic Estate Wines	Santa Barbara	0 of 48	1 to 3 of 48

Largest declines

Winery	County	Q2 2026	This quarter
Brewer-Clifton	Santa Barbara	18 of 48	9 to 14 of 48
Chamisal Vineyards	San Luis Obispo	22 of 48	15 to 18 of 48
Dragonette Cellars	Santa Barbara	12 of 48	5 to 8 of 48
Zaca Mesa Winery	Santa Barbara	24 of 48	17 to 19 of 48
Fess Parker Winery	Santa Barbara	28 of 48	21 to 24 of 48
Foxen Winery	Santa Barbara	13 of 48	7 to 9 of 48
Hitching Post Wines	Santa Barbara	8 of 48	3 to 4 of 48
Kalyra Winery	Santa Barbara	10 of 48	5 to 8 of 48
Saucelito Canyon	San Luis Obispo	10 of 48	5 to 9 of 48
Stolpman Vineyards	Santa Barbara	17 of 48	12 to 15 of 48

> **Why it matters:** A winery that comes up less often on the shortlist is likely to lose some of the visitors who ask, whether or not anything changed at the winery.

The Five Most Common Gaps

The five gaps we found most often across the 442 wineries in both counties, in the categories that take sustained work, each counted only where we could check. Under each, why it costs a winery.

1. Not in the search results for “wine tasting” searches: 338 of 442 wineries

A visitor who searches for wineries, not for you by name, never sees you in those results.

2. No press on the first page of its own name search: 332 of 442 wineries

Independent coverage is what tells a visitor, and an AI assistant, that someone else vouches for you.

3. Not in the Google Maps results for discovery searches: 273 of 442 wineries

The visitor searching the map from the car picks from what the map shows.

4. No new reviews in 90 days: 100 of the 429 wineries we could check

A profile that has gone quiet likely reads as a place that has gone quiet.

5. Few or no Google reviews: 72 of 442 wineries

Wineries with more Google reviews are named more often; that doesn’t prove reviews cause it, but it’s the strongest link in our data.

Your county edition counts three of these gaps across your county (few Google reviews, press and Maps) and ranks every winery on every category. Monitor tells you which of them you are missing and in which order to fix them; Monitor Plus adds the peers you name, beside you.

The Market Around You

The good news: our two counties held their value

In a hard year for California grapes, the county crop reports show our two counties held up. The Santa Barbara County crop report values its 2025 wine grapes at $87.8 million, up 24%; San Luis Obispo County's crop statistics put its crop at $196.1 million, flat against $195.0 million in 2024. The same county reports elsewhere fell: Monterey down 25%, Sonoma down 17%, Napa down 6%. USDA's 2025 grape acreage report, in the acreage growers report standing in its county tables, young vines included, shows acreage here slipping more slowly than the state's: 1.9% in San Luis Obispo County and 0.9% in Santa Barbara County, against 3.7% for the state's reported total.

The hard part: grapes fetch less a ton

USDA's Final Grape Crush report, which records the average price paid per ton, puts District 8, the state's pricing district for San Luis Obispo, Santa Barbara and Ventura counties, at $1,751.14 a ton for the 2025 crop, down 6.9% from $1,881.03, a steeper fall than the state's 3.9%. Allied Grape Growers, as reported by the Associated Press, estimates that about half of California's 2026 crop went into harvest without a buyer contract, against 70 to 80% contracted in a typical year. USDA's estimate of all California wine-grape acreage, a wider measure than the reported acreage above, fell 6.9% in 2025, to 540,000 acres. In Paso Robles, the Wine Country Alliance's benchmark of its reporting wineries shows tasting room visitors down 7% in the twelve months through August 2026, the same fall as its California benchmark, and revenue per visitor down 2%, against a 3% rise for California.

The good news again: the direct sale

Fruit is a buyer's market this year. A winery that buys grapes has room to secure better fruit or longer terms, and an estate with surplus fruit has more reason to bottle it and sell it direct. The direct sale is the part of the business each winery controls, and it is what the rest of this report measures. Regions are betting on it too: Santa Barbara County's Wine Improvement District reported to the county's supervisors that the "Let's Go!" campaign reached more than 16 million consumers and brought about 66,000 new visitors to its website in two months.

The Leaders

One list per category across both counties: the ten highest scores among all 442 wineries we measure, with the county each sits in. Where so many share the top score that a list would rank nothing, we show instead the gaps that keep the rest from it.

Overall Digital Readiness (of 100)

What it measures: the seven categories below, added up into one score for how easy a winery is to find, trust, book and buy from online.

#	Winery	Score	County
1	JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery	81.7	San Luis Obispo
2	Roblar Winery	77.1	Santa Barbara
3	Sunstone Winery	74.4	Santa Barbara
4	Laetitia Vineyard & Winery	74.1	San Luis Obispo
5	Eberle Winery	73.1	San Luis Obispo
6	Fess Parker Winery	73.0	Santa Barbara
7	Carhartt Family Wines	71.2	Santa Barbara
8	Alma Rosa Winery & Vineyards	70.9	Santa Barbara
9	Wolff Vineyards	69.2	San Luis Obispo
10	Chamisal Vineyards	68.3	San Luis Obispo

Third-Party Presence (of 23)

What it measures: do the lists, guides, and press that visitors and AI assistants read name you? Who else says you are worth visiting.

#	Winery	Score	County
1	Alma Rosa Winery & Vineyards	18.5	Santa Barbara
2	Laetitia Vineyard & Winery	17.2	San Luis Obispo
3	DAOU Vineyards	16.0	San Luis Obispo
4	Eberle Winery	16.0	San Luis Obispo
5	ONX Wines	16.0	San Luis Obispo
6	Brewer-Clifton	15.2	Santa Barbara
7	Castoro Cellars Vineyards & Winery	15.2	San Luis Obispo

Scores are shared in this category: three of the seven wineries listed here scored 16.0 and the next score, 14.0, is shared by 10 of the 442 wineries in our two counties, more than the table has room for, so it stops at seven. Wineries sharing a score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other, at the top of the table as much as at the cut.

Review Volume & Reputation (of 25)

What it measures: how many people vouch for you, and are they still doing it? The pre-planner's starting point. Volume and recent reviews count; a high rating on a handful of reviews no longer carries the category.

#	Winery	Score	County
1	DAOU Vineyards	23.7	San Luis Obispo
2	JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery	23.7	San Luis Obispo
3	Sculpterra Winery and Sculpture Garden	22.3	San Luis Obispo
4	Tobin James Cellars	22.3	San Luis Obispo
5	Sunstone Winery	20.4	Santa Barbara
6	Calcareous Vineyard	19.7	San Luis Obispo
7	Niner Wine Estates	19.7	San Luis Obispo
8	Laetitia Vineyard & Winery	19.2	San Luis Obispo
9	Austin Hope Winery	19.1	San Luis Obispo
10	Halter Ranch Vineyard	18.7	San Luis Obispo

Scores are shared in this category: two of the ten wineries listed here scored 23.7. Wineries sharing a score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other, at the top of the table as much as at the cut.

Search & Map Discovery (of 21)

What it measures: when a visitor searches for wineries rather than for you by name, do you come up, in the results and on the map? The searches a visitor types before they have your name.

#	Winery	Score	County
1	Sunstone Winery	18.6	Santa Barbara
2	Chamisal Vineyards	17.1	San Luis Obispo
3	Roblar Winery	17.1	Santa Barbara
4	Buttonwood Farm Winery	16.7	Santa Barbara
5	Copia Vineyards and Winery	16.1	San Luis Obispo
6	JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery	16.1	San Luis Obispo
7	Fess Parker Winery	14.7	Santa Barbara
8	LXV Wine & Pairings Downtown	14.7	San Luis Obispo
9	Vina Robles Vineyards & Winery	14.7	San Luis Obispo

Scores are shared in this category: two of the nine wineries listed here scored 17.1 and the next score, 14.3, is shared by 3 of the 442 wineries in our two counties, more than the table has room for, so it stops at nine. Wineries sharing a score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other, at the top of the table as much as at the cut.

AI-Ready Booking & Buying (of 14)

What it measures: once someone has picked you, can they book, join, and buy without picking up the phone? Where an interested visitor either completes or leaks away.

18 of the 442 wineries we measure scored the full 14 points on AI-Ready Booking & Buying, so a list of the first ten would rank nothing. What separates the rest is what they are missing.

The most common gaps, and how many wineries have them:

What we check	Wineries missing it	Of those we could check
Tasting fee on a tasting page	238	414
Shipping cost shown on the site	233	438
Visit hours on its own site	147	438
Ships direct	128	438
Online reservations	106	438
A visit page	105	438
A modern checkout	28	438

These are the questions a visitor, and an assistant answering for one, asks just before booking: what does it cost, when are you open, can I book, will you ship. A missing answer is likely to send some visitors to the next winery on the list.

Profile Accuracy (of 6)

What it measures: does your Google profile state the right facts, and does Apple Maps agree? The facts a map or an assistant repeats about you.

92 of the 442 wineries we measure scored the full 6 points on Profile Accuracy, so a list of the first ten would rank nothing. What separates the rest is what they are missing.

The most common gaps, and how many wineries have them:

What we check	Wineries missing it	Of those we could check
Google secondary categories	227	442
Google hours complete	74	442
Google profile claimed	42	442
Apple and Google agree on the address	21	373
Apple and Google agree on the phone	21	365
Google attributes set	19	442
Google profile links the website	17	442
Google primary category is Winery	14	427

The Google profile is what a map, and an assistant reading it, repeats about you. A profile with gaps is a profile that answers some visitors wrongly or not at all.

Citation Readiness (of 6)

What it measures: when a search engine or AI assistant reads your site, can it get the facts out? Your own site is one place answers get their facts.

21 of the 442 wineries we measure scored the full 6 points on Citation Readiness, so a list of the first ten would rank nothing. What separates the rest is what they are missing.

The most common gaps, and how many wineries have them:

What we check	Wineries missing it	Of those we could check
Store prices readable without JavaScript	242	414
Club prices readable without JavaScript	223	429
Tasting notes on the site	216	438
Pages with real substance	90	438
Store page readable without JavaScript	78	414
Club page readable without JavaScript	43	429
Page speed	12	433
Works on a phone	12	438
robots.txt allows AI search bots	6	440

An assistant can only repeat what it can read. Prices and pages that appear only after JavaScript runs are likely not what many AI crawlers read, so an assistant asked “how much is the club” may have nothing to say.

Social (of 5)

What it measures: does your Instagram confirm you’re open, active, and worth visiting? Instagram is likely how many wine country visitors check their shortlist.

#	Winery	Score	County
1	DAOU Vineyards	5.0	San Luis Obispo
2	Riboli Family of San Antonio Winery, Bistro + Tasting Room	5.0	San Luis Obispo

Scores are shared in this category: the next score, 4.6, is shared by 10 of the 442 wineries in our two counties, more than the table has room for, so it stops at two. Wineries sharing a score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other, at the top of the table as much as at the cut.

Where Do You Stand?

Three questions this edition cannot answer for you:

1. Are you among the 45 wineries that account for 47.5% of every time AI names a winery, or among the 54 never named in an answer to their own county’s questions?

2. Which of the gaps in this edition are yours?

3. Did your neighbors gain on you this quarter?

Where to Go from Here

Book a 30-minute call: calendly.com/scott_mainstreetiq/30min

How we measure, in brief. We track every active winery in the two counties that sells its own wine to the public, by visit, club or mailing list, and scored 442 of them this quarter, each measured at one location, on seven categories from public sources only: no surveys, no self-reporting, no private analytics. Separately we ask six AI assistants the trip-planning questions a visitor would ask about each county, three times over the month, and count which wineries they name; that result is never part of the score. What Changed compares quarters on a smaller set kept unchanged from Q2 2026: 12 questions per county put to four assistants. The county editions set out the full method.

Sources for The Market Around You: USDA NASS, California Grape Crush Report, Final 2025 (April 30, 2026); USDA NASS, California Grape Acreage Report, 2025 Crop (April 29, 2026); Santa Barbara County Agricultural Commissioner, Crop & Livestock Report 2025 (June 23, 2026); San Luis Obispo County Agricultural Commissioner, 2025 crop statistics, Board of Supervisors agenda for October 6, 2026; Monterey, Napa, Sonoma and San Joaquin County Agricultural Commissioners, 2025 crop reports (July to September 2026); Associated Press, "Farmers toil to sell grapes as wine demand drops" (September 27, 2026); Paso Robles Wine Country Alliance, Community Benchmark: Paso Robles vs California, rolling 12 months through August 2026 (posted October 6, 2026); Santa Barbara County Wine Improvement District, FY 2026-27 Annual Report, Board of Supervisors file 26-00813, Attachment A (September 1, 2026).

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About Main Street IQ

Main Street IQ gives businesses the kind of rigorous outside analysis that used to be reserved for companies big enough to hire a consulting firm. For wineries, that means an honest read on where you stand against the wineries around you, which gaps are most likely to be costing you visits and club signups, and a clear order to fix them in. We use AI to do much of the reading and counting, which is how the analysis stays thorough and the cost stays within reach of a working winery.

Scott Hess, who founded the practice, spent twenty years in finance and operations before it. Much of that was in corporate finance at Northern Trust, supporting the leadership of the business, and embedded with luxury and owner-operated brands where the founder still makes every call that matters. The lesson carried across all of it: what decides whether a business grows is usually visible from the outside long before it surfaces in the ledger, and the owner is the last person with time to go looking for it. That is the gap this practice was built to close.

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